

48 Ways to Get More from Your Health-Care Dollar

In *Stay Healthy, Live Longer, Spend Wisely: Making Intelligent Choices in America's Healthcare System*, Dr. Davis Liu describes how health insurance premiums grew 73% compared to wage increases of 15% from 2000 to 2005. Here are nearly 50 ways to save money without compromising your well-being, drawn from Dr. Liu's book and my experience, research, and wisdom of the Wise Bread community.

1. Review all medical bills and question anything that doesn't seem right, especially services that should be covered under your insurance plan; talk to your insurance agent, employee benefits counselor, and/or insurance company representative to make sure that covered items are paid correctly.
2. Call your physician's office to ask about a nonurgent problem (or to see if a symptom requires immediate treatment) rather than scheduling an appointment.
3. Ask your pharmacist about medications including prescriptions, over-the-counter drugs, and behind-the-counter remedies; you'll get free, valuable advice from a health-care professional who has spent many years studying medicines.
4. Compare your physician's recommendations with clinical guidelines (e.g., pediatrics, obstetrics/gynecology, urology); ask about anything that you don't understand or seems to be unusual care.
5. Do self-exams.
6. Get high-deductible health-care insurance rather than forgoing insurance because the uninsured have higher death rates from chronic disease and accidents.
7. Carry continuous coverage so that exclusions for preexisting conditions will be limited according to federal law associated with HIPAA (Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act).
8. If you may lose your job or already have lost your job, compare the cost of COBRA coverage (extended to displaced employees